COVID-19 during the second wave, there were those who saw her use the tragedy to get sympathetic coverage in the international media using the emotion of grief to further her agenda.[3] Multiple countries have seen a large number of deaths but the fascination of covering crematoriums in India among a section of Indian and international media has never been seen elsewhere. With the media flooded with pictures of floating bodies and overloaded crematoriums, several folks began to question if India was revealing the true figures of the COVID-19 death toll.

Typically, two out of three deaths in India occur at home and only about 86 per cent of all deaths are registered. In other words, 14 out of 100 deaths, even outside of a pandemic situation go entirely uncounted which is why researchers choose to use demographic surveys to confirm death rate.[4] Death rates in India are generally calculated from data extrapolated from the Civil Registration System (CRS) and the Sample Registration System (SRS). Now, it is also crucial to note that the government has increasingly invested in digitizing birth and death records which has had a positive impact on actual registration. In 2011, only 66 per cent of deaths were registered versus in 2019, when registrations increased to 92 per cent.[5]

The CRS is the body responsible for recording death data from local governments across states. It releases and corrects data after a considerable time lag. While data reporting highly varies across states, in rural areas deaths of women and children especially go unregistered. The SRS, on the other hand, is a large-scale demographic survey which is conducted annually by the Office of the Registrar General & Census Commissioner in India. Usually, the sample consists of 4,961 rural and 3,886 urban units covering a population of approximately 8.1 million people across states and UTs and is then adjusted relative to the entire population to calculate for total estimated deaths. However, the problem lies in the fact that death estimates from both systems vary significantly. Take the year 2019 for instance: according to the CRS, India had 1.1 million excess deaths as compared to average figures of 2015–18, but according to the SRS, death numbers from the same time period show that there was a marginal decline in deaths. In addition to these issues, for access to better medical facilities, folks from rural parts of the country travel to urban and semi-urban areas. If casualties occur in these urban areas where treatment centres are concentrated, that’s where deaths would be registered, showing as a spike in death rates in urban areas versus rural ones. However, looking at this data